

The importer's lens

How the person across the table decides. Five checks, learned from fifteen years of watching pitches land or die.

01 THE FIVE CHECKS

- 1 · Proof at home.** Awards, listings, velocity. A track record is a readiness asset; 'great tequila, great bottle' is not a pitch.
- 2 · Their math.** Does your realistic volume make the importer real money? A niche single SKU that earns them little is a polite no.
- 3 · Backwards price.** From the Indian shelf, through margins and duty, to your invoice. If you have not done the walk-back, they will, without you.
- 4 · A portfolio.** A distinctive door-opener plus a volume workhorse beats one hero bottle. Mezcal opens doors.
- 5 · A committed owner.** Dedicated representation and fast decisions. Commission agents carrying 10 to 30 brands sell whatever is easiest.

02 THE FIRST MEETING · WHAT THEY WILL ASK

Expect these questions: monthly capacity and lead times; exclusivity, national or state-wise; what marketing support you fund; your payment terms; and who in your house says yes. Rehearse the answers before Phase 4; your pitch card will carry them.

03 RED FLAGS THEY SMELL IN MINUTES

- Pricing fantasy:** a shelf ambition your FOB cannot reach. The walk-back in File 05 prevents this.
- No decision-maker:** 'I will check with the family' twice in one meeting ends the meeting.
- Desperation:** offering everything to everyone. Exclusivity has value only when you understand what you are trading it for.

04 WHAT TO HAVE READY

Before any meeting: your landed-cost model, an English brand deck, proof points, your terms position, and a named decision-maker.

THE POINT

Phase 4 opens the doors. Files 05 and 08 are what you carry through them.